



The AI Recommendation Economy

How AI is changing the way customers buy, choose, and trust businesses

A Gateway Commerce AI Findability Guide

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Why This Matters Now

The internet is entering a new operating model. For years, digital visibility was mostly about whether customers could find a page, click a result, and compare options for themselves. That world still exists, but it is no longer the whole story. Customers are increasingly asking AI systems to interpret a problem, compare choices, summarize evidence, and recommend what to do next.

That change creates a business risk many executives cannot yet see in their dashboards. A company may have a good website, strong people, satisfied customers, and a credible brand, yet still be difficult for AI systems to understand. If the public evidence is scattered, generic, outdated, blocked, or poorly structured, AI may summarize the business weakly, omit it from a recommendation, or flatten it into the same language used for every competitor.

The goal of this guide is to help leaders think about visibility as a connected business system. Search, paid media, social media, YouTube, reviews, structured data, testimonials, source-of-truth pages, and customer proof all contribute to whether a company can be found, understood, trusted, and recommended. The companies that win will not be the ones that merely produce more content. They will be the ones that organize better evidence.

This is also why AI visibility should not be treated as a technology project alone. It is a revenue, reputation, and competitive-positioning issue. The technical work matters, but the larger question is strategic: can customers and AI systems clearly understand why your company deserves to be chosen?

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Chapter 1: Digital Success Still Starts with Getting Found

Digital success has always had two linked problems. First, the right people have to find you. Second, once they arrive, you have to keep them long enough to earn trust, answer their questions, and move them toward action. Most digital strategy discussions mix those two problems together, but they are different disciplines. Acquisition is about visibility, relevance, findability, and recommendation. Conversion is about experience, clarity, trust, usability, merchandising, pricing, proof, and follow-through.

This guide is primarily about the first problem: how a company gets discovered, understood, and recommended when customers increasingly use AI systems as part of their decision process. That does not mean conversion is less important. In fact, traffic without conversion is just expensive noise. A company can become more visible in Google, YouTube, ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Perplexity, Copilot, or Bing and still lose the customer if the site is slow, confusing, unsupported, generic, or poorly matched to the buyer's actual question. But before a site can convert a visitor, the visitor has to get there, or the company has to be recommended strongly enough that the customer already trusts it before the first click.

That is why the website remains central even in an AI world. Some people assume AI makes websites less important because the answer may appear before the click. I see the opposite. The website becomes more important because it is the most controllable evidence layer the business owns. It tells search engines and AI systems who the company is, what it sells, who it serves, what proof supports its claims, which products or services matter, and why a buyer should choose it over alternatives.

The dryer-timer example illustrates the shift. I already knew the problem: the timer knob would no longer turn. What I needed was not a long list of blue links. I needed the correct part, a reliable place to order it, and instructions for replacing it. With a phone and Gemini, that task moved from search to action. The lesson for business leaders is not that every customer journey will look exactly like a dryer repair. The lesson is that customers increasingly expect technology to collapse the distance between question, confidence, and action.

More Everyday Examples

Travel planning shows the same pattern in a more complex consumer journey. I have now planned three vacations with AI. For a trip to Utah, the value was not simply finding a list of national parks. The value was asking AI to recommend which parks to visit, in what order, where to stay, what to do at each park for someone my age, and where to eat along the way. That is a different task than searching for 'best Utah

parks' or opening twenty browser tabs. AI became a planning layer that interpreted constraints, sequenced decisions, and turned scattered information into an itinerary.

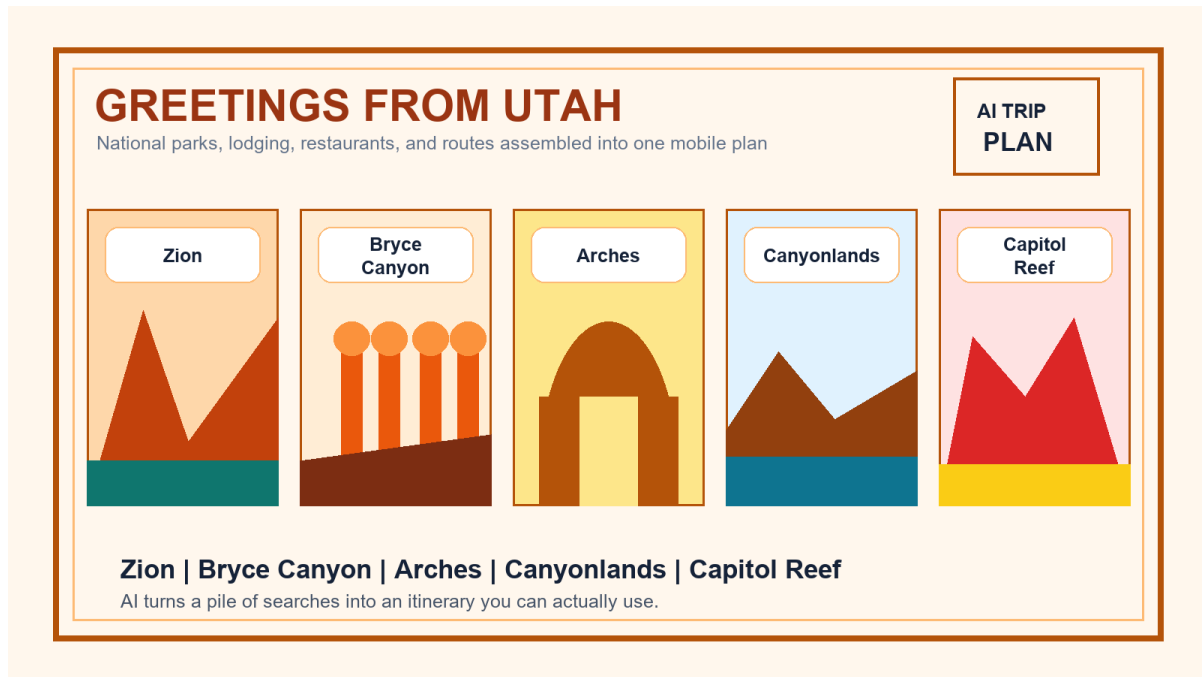


Figure 1: AI turns scattered travel searches into a usable plan.

The second step was even more revealing. After the Utah itinerary was built, I turned it into a phone app with relevant links to every hotel, park, restaurant, and activity so the plan could be used while traveling. That moved AI from answer engine to operating tool. The output was no longer just information to read before the trip. It became a portable decision system I could use in the moment, from my phone, while standing in a park, choosing a restaurant, checking a hotel, or adjusting the day's plan.

I used the same approach for a five-day visit to San Antonio. Again, the point was not that AI knew more than every travel site. The point was that it reduced planning friction. It could hold the trip length, interests, age-related preferences, location, restaurants, attractions, timing, and links together in one working plan. Instead of bouncing between search results, maps, hotel sites, restaurant pages, attraction pages, and notes, AI helped assemble a practical travel experience.

This behavior is already showing up in the market. McKinsey's travel research reports that less than a third of travelers had used gen AI for travel-related tasks at the time of the survey, but 84 percent of those users said the tools improved their experience. The same McKinsey summary notes common uses including general research, travel inspiration, local food recommendations, transportation planning, itinerary creation, and budgeting. Gemini's own travel-planning materials describe the same shift: fewer tabs, more conversational planning, and AI that can connect travel ideas to flights, hotels, restaurants, routes, and local discovery. [17] [18]

The business implication is enormous. A hotel, restaurant, tour operator, attraction, local service provider, or retailer is no longer competing only for a search click. It is competing to be included in the itinerary AI

builds. If AI cannot understand the business, location, audience fit, hours, reviews, accessibility, pricing, menu, booking path, or unique value, the business may never make it into the plan. And if it is not in the plan, the customer may never know it was an option.

Consumer task	Old behavior	AI-enabled behavior	Business implication
Home repair	Search model numbers, forums, parts diagrams, and videos.	Take a photo, describe the known problem, ask for the part, purchase link, and repair steps.	Parts sellers and service providers need clear product data, compatibility, instructions, and trustworthy pages.
Utah vacation planning	Search parks, hotels, restaurants, maps, and activities separately.	Ask for a sequenced itinerary by age, interests, park order, lodging, restaurants, and daily activities.	Parks, hotels, restaurants, and attractions need to be understandable enough to be included in AI-built itineraries.
San Antonio city visit	Compare travel blogs, maps, hotel sites, restaurant lists, and attraction pages.	Build a five-day working plan with relevant links and mobile access.	Local businesses compete to become part of the recommended plan, not merely to rank for a generic query.
Restaurant choice	Search 'best near me,' scan reviews, and compare menus.	Ask for a meal recommendation based on location, dietary needs, timing, price, and atmosphere.	Menus, hours, reviews, reservation links, and distinctive positioning become machine-readable decision inputs.
Product purchase	Compare retail pages, reviews, videos, and marketplaces.	Ask which product fits a need, budget, use case, and constraint.	Product data, specs, reviews, comparison content, availability, and support materials influence whether AI recommends the product.
Healthcare preparation	Search symptoms or unfamiliar test results across many sites.	Ask AI to explain information and prepare better questions for a physician.	Providers need clear, accurate, trustworthy educational content that supports informed conversations without replacing professional care.

For executives, the question becomes practical: if a customer describes a problem your company solves, will AI understand your company well enough to include it in the answer? If it does, will the answer be specific, current, and differentiated? If it does not, your website may still exist, your content may still be good, and your brand may still be known to humans, but the systems shaping early consideration may not know how to place you.

The rest of this guide focuses on building that bridge: from being present online to being legible, from being legible to being trusted, and from being trusted to being recommended. Conversion, customer experience, and revenue optimization come next. They deserve their own treatment because getting visitors to the site is only the beginning. Once they are there, a business has to make sure it does not lose them.

Chapter 2: From Search Economy to Recommendation Economy

For more than two decades, companies learned to compete in the search economy. The rules were not simple, but the mental model was clear enough: customers searched, engines returned pages, companies optimized pages, and buyers clicked through to compare options. SEO, paid search, content marketing, and analytics grew around that model. Even when the tools changed, the basic pattern stayed recognizable.

AI changes the shape of that journey because it moves part of the comparison work into the answer itself. A customer can now ask for a recommendation, describe constraints, upload an image, compare alternatives, ask follow-up questions, and request a buying path in one conversation. The customer is not merely looking for information. The customer is asking a system to help reason through a decision.

From Search Results to Recommended Action

The customer journey is compressing from many separate steps into one guided conversation.

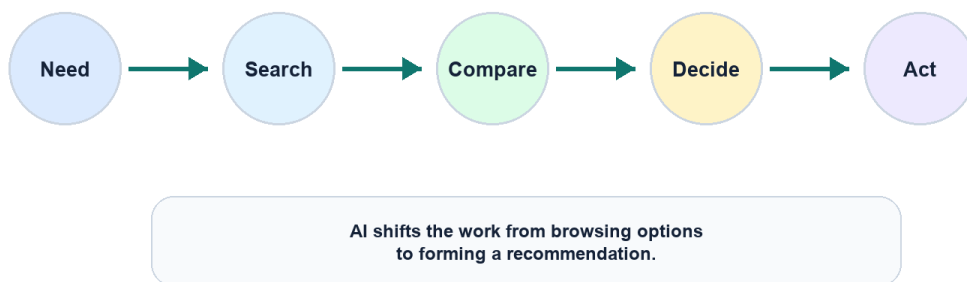


Figure 2: The customer journey compresses from search results to recommended action.

That distinction matters. Search produced choices. AI increasingly produces recommendations, summaries, comparisons, and next steps. A search engine might show ten results and leave the customer to compare them. An AI assistant may explain three options, recommend one, and summarize why. The company that wins may not be the company with the best-looking homepage. It may be the company the system can explain most confidently.

This does not mean Google search disappears. It does not mean SEO is dead. It means SEO becomes part of a larger visibility system. Companies still need crawlable pages, clear titles, useful content, credible links, structured data, strong technical foundations, and persuasive landing pages. But they also need evidence that AI systems can retrieve, interpret, compare, and use to ground answers.

The executive shift is simple but profound: businesses are no longer competing only to be found. They are competing to be understood well enough to be recommended. That requires a different type of discipline because the answer may be assembled from many signals: website content, structured data, reviews, third-party mentions, public documents, videos, transcripts, product feeds, support content, local listings, and social proof. Some practitioners now call this discipline generative engine optimization, or GEO, and answer engine optimization, or AEO. The labels are less important than the shift they describe: optimizing for inclusion in an assembled answer, not only for a ranked position on a results page.

Chapter 3: Why AI Visibility Is Different from SEO

Traditional SEO asks whether a page can rank for a query. AI visibility asks whether a company can be accurately understood and confidently recommended for a buyer's problem. Those questions overlap, but they are not identical. A page can rank and still fail to give AI enough context to explain why the business matters. A company can have strong content and still be difficult for AI systems to connect to specific products, services, locations, proof points, or customer outcomes.

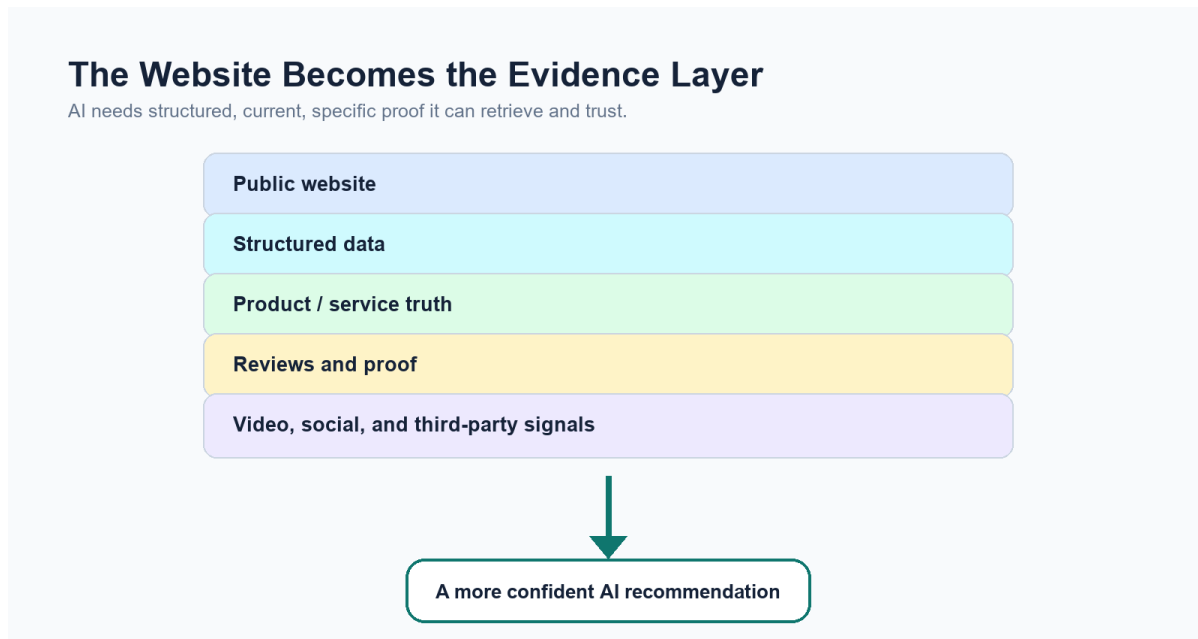


Figure 3: The website becomes the evidence layer AI systems can retrieve and trust.

Google's structured data guidance describes structured markup as a way to help search systems understand the content on a page and make it eligible for enhanced search features. In the AI Recommendation Economy, that same principle becomes even more important: the clearer the machine-readable evidence, the easier it is for AI systems to interpret and reuse the business accurately. Structured data does not replace useful content, but it helps machines connect visible claims to specific entities, products, services, reviews, FAQs, authors, events, organizations, and local details. [5] In practice, that means naming the specific schema types tied to buyer decisions, such as FAQPage for buyer questions, Product for specs and pricing, and Review or AggregateRating for social proof, rather than stopping at organization-level markup.

AI visibility also depends on access. If crawlers cannot reach the site, if important content is hidden behind scripts or authentication, if firewalls block useful bots indiscriminately, or if robots.txt rules are too restrictive, the business may accidentally make itself invisible. This is why the bot allowlist and technical review are not minor IT details. They are part of the revenue system.

One access question executives now raise is llms.txt, a proposed file for pointing AI systems to a site's most trustworthy content. No major AI vendor has confirmed using it for crawling, grounding, or ranking, so it is worth adopting as a hygiene signal rather than relied on as a guaranteed lever over AI answers.

But access is not enough. A business must also avoid ambiguity. AI systems are very good at summarizing broad categories. They are less reliable when a company's difference is implied rather than clearly stated. If the site says the same things every competitor says, AI may flatten the company into the same generic description. Specificity, evidence, comparison context, and current information become strategic assets. Harvard Business Review's guidance on brand readiness for agentic AI makes the same point from the monitoring side: companies that regularly check what AI systems say about them, and correct inaccurate or thin summaries, are better positioned than companies that only publish and wait. [10]

Chapter 4: Paid Media, Social Media, and AI Findability

Paid media and social media do matter in the AI visibility conversation, but not in the simplistic way many people assume. Buying Google Ads does not improve organic Google ranking; Google states that advertising programs are independent from organic search results and that buying ads does not positively or negatively affect inclusion or ranking in Google Search. Google Ads documentation makes the same separation clear while noting that paid and organic results can be measured together to understand total visibility and clicks. [1] [2]

That means paid search should not be described as a shortcut to SEO or AI visibility. Its value is different. Paid search can create immediate visibility while organic and AI visibility work builds over time. It can reveal which queries convert, which offers resonate, which landing pages fail, and which audience segments deserve dedicated content. Used well, paid media becomes a learning system. It helps the business identify the questions, phrases, pain points, and proof points that should later be reflected in durable site content.

Paid media also has an indirect role in brand evidence. If a campaign drives the right prospects to a strong page, and those prospects engage, share, link, review, or discuss the company elsewhere, the campaign may help create signals that outlive the ad spend. But the ad itself should not be treated as ranking fuel. The durable asset is the learning, the landing page, the content improvement, the earned attention, and the clearer evidence layer that remains after the campaign ends.

Social media plays a related but different role. Public social content can help establish topical authority, demonstrate expertise, distribute useful ideas, and create repeated associations between a person, company, problem, and point of view. It can also lead people, publishers, creators, customers, partners, and industry voices back to stronger owned content. The important boundary is quality: social should support real authority, not simulate it through artificial promotion, shallow engagement, or content that has no durable evidence behind it. [3] [4]

YouTube belongs in this section because it is a major search and discovery surface, especially for how-to guidance, product research, travel ideas, repairs, reviews, demonstrations, and education. Bing remains the

second-largest traditional web search engine by StatCounter's global search-engine share, though StatCounter tracks YouTube separately rather than in that same ranking. YouTube's own search documentation says results are shaped by relevance, engagement, and quality, including how well titles, descriptions, tags, and video content match the query. For AI visibility, that means useful videos, clear descriptions, transcripts, and links back to authoritative site content can become part of the evidence layer. [20] [21]

Visibility Is a Channel Constellation

Paid, social, YouTube, SEO, and AI assistants all shape the evidence customers encounter.



Figure 4: Paid, social, YouTube, SEO, and AI assistants form a connected visibility system.

For AI findability, social media is most useful when it reinforces a clear entity and evidence strategy. A founder who consistently explains a category, a company page that links back to authoritative resources, videos with transcripts, customer stories, expert commentary, and well-structured posts can all help create a richer public footprint. The mistake is treating social as a replacement for the website. Social platforms are rented distribution. The website is the owned evidence base.

Channel	Direct role	Best use in AI visibility
Paid search	Immediate query-level visibility; does not directly improve organic rankings.	Test buyer language, offers, and landing pages before investing heavily in permanent content.
Paid social	Targeted distribution to specific audiences; not a substitute for search authority.	Validate messaging, collect engagement signals, and drive prospects to strong owned assets.
Organic social	Repeated public association between expertise, category, people, and proof.	Create recognizable authority and generate earned links, citations, conversations, and demand.
SEO / content	Durable owned visibility and crawlable evidence.	Turn campaign learning and customer questions into structured, authoritative pages.

Tying the Channels Together

The strongest companies do not treat the website, YouTube, LinkedIn, Facebook, review platforms, and sales materials as separate islands. They use each channel to reinforce the same entity, the same expertise, the same customer problems, and the same proof. That consistency matters because search engines, AI systems, and customers are all trying to answer a basic trust question: is this the same company, saying the same thing, with enough outside evidence to believe it?

The website should serve as the source of truth. Google organization structured data allows a company to declare core facts such as its name, URL, logo, contact information, and related external profile pages. Schema.org's Organization vocabulary also includes the sameAs property, which can point to authoritative profiles and pages that represent the same organization. Used carefully, that structure helps connect the company's owned site to its official LinkedIn page, Facebook page, YouTube channel, industry listings, review profiles, and other durable references. [23] [24]

YouTube testimonials are especially valuable because they combine proof, emotion, language, and specificity. Published research on electronic word-of-mouth and online reviews consistently shows that usefulness, credibility, review valence, reviewer trustworthiness, source expertise, and similarity between the reviewer and audience influence purchase intention. Research on video bloggers also points to trustworthiness, expertise, homophily, and content quality as drivers of behavioral intention. The practical lesson is straightforward: testimonials should not sit off to the side as praise. They should become structured evidence of why the company is different. [25] [26] [27]

The operating model is to turn every strong testimonial into a proof asset. A customer video on YouTube should have a clear title, description, tags, chapter markers when appropriate, and a link back to the most relevant page on the company website. The website should embed the video, summarize the business problem, include a short transcript or key quotes, identify the product or service involved, state the outcome, and link to related case studies or service pages. YouTube's own search guidance emphasizes relevance, engagement, and quality, including how well the title, tags, description, and video content match the query. Academic research on YouTube marketing also supports the importance of video optimization practices such as title information, description content, and tags for video views. [21] [28]

LinkedIn and Facebook should play a supporting role in this system. They are useful for distribution, executive voice, community validation, customer comments, and repeated association between the company and its category. But the most important posts should point back to owned proof pages, not only to social engagement. A LinkedIn post can introduce the customer problem, the YouTube testimonial can show the customer's voice, the website can preserve the structured proof, and schema can help machines reconcile the relationship between those assets.

This is also how a company reduces flattening risk. If AI sees only generic website copy, it may describe the business generically. If AI can also see a clear source-of-truth page, consistent social profiles, embedded YouTube testimonials, transcripts, customer outcomes, industry-specific examples, and third-party reviews, it has more evidence to explain why the business is different. The goal is not to manufacture reputation. The goal is to organize real reputation so people and machines can understand it.

Channel Architecture: One Company, Many Proof Points

The website anchors the facts. Social, video, reviews, and profiles reinforce the same identity.

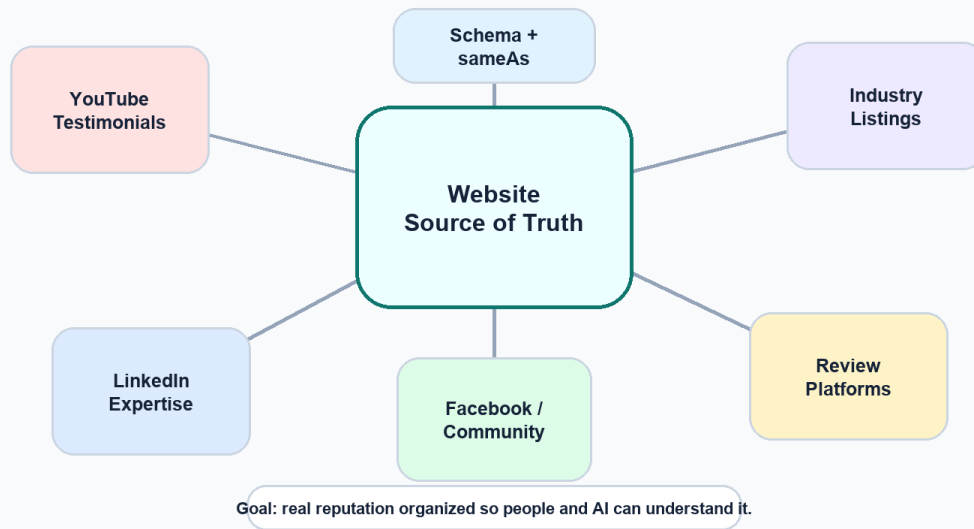


Figure 5: The website anchors the facts while social, video, reviews, profiles, and schema reinforce the same company identity.

Chapter 5: The Flattening Risk

Flattening is the risk that AI compresses a company into the category average. If a site uses generic claims, thin proof, interchangeable language, vague positioning, and weak structure, AI has little reason to preserve what makes that business different. The answer may be technically accurate and still commercially damaging because it reduces the company to a bland summary alongside everyone else.

The Flattening Risk

When evidence is vague, AI may compress strong businesses into generic category language.



Figure 6: Specific evidence helps prevent AI from flattening the business into the category average.

This is one of the most important ideas in the guide. In a traditional search result, a customer might see the brand name, page title, meta description, star rating, and surrounding listings, then decide what to click. In an AI-mediated answer, the system may summarize the category and mention a few options. If the company has not made its differentiation clear, AI may describe it with the same words it uses for competitors: reliable, innovative, customer-focused, full-service, trusted, comprehensive. Those words do not create preference. Harvard Business Review has documented how far this drift can go: researchers found that one leading AI model miscategorized Ballantine's Scotch, an affordable mass-market whisky, as a prestige product, simply because the brand's public evidence did not make the distinction clear. [9]

External commentary on AI flattening and brand blandness points to the same concern: when machine-generated summaries prioritize common patterns and average language, originality can be diluted. The executive lesson is not to write content for machines instead of humans. The lesson is to make the real difference explicit enough that both people and machines can understand it. [11] [12]

The antidote to flattening is evidence. Specific services, named customer problems, measurable outcomes, comparison pages, case examples, schema, FAQs, leadership expertise, product data, support documentation, video transcripts, and third-party references all help AI preserve a company's distinctiveness. Without that evidence, even a strong business can look ordinary.

Chapter 6: The Executive AI Visibility Scorecard

The scorecard gives executives a way to assess AI visibility without turning the discussion into a technical scavenger hunt. The goal is not to produce a perfect number. The goal is to create a practical conversation about whether the business is accessible, understandable, differentiated, trusted, current, and measurable.

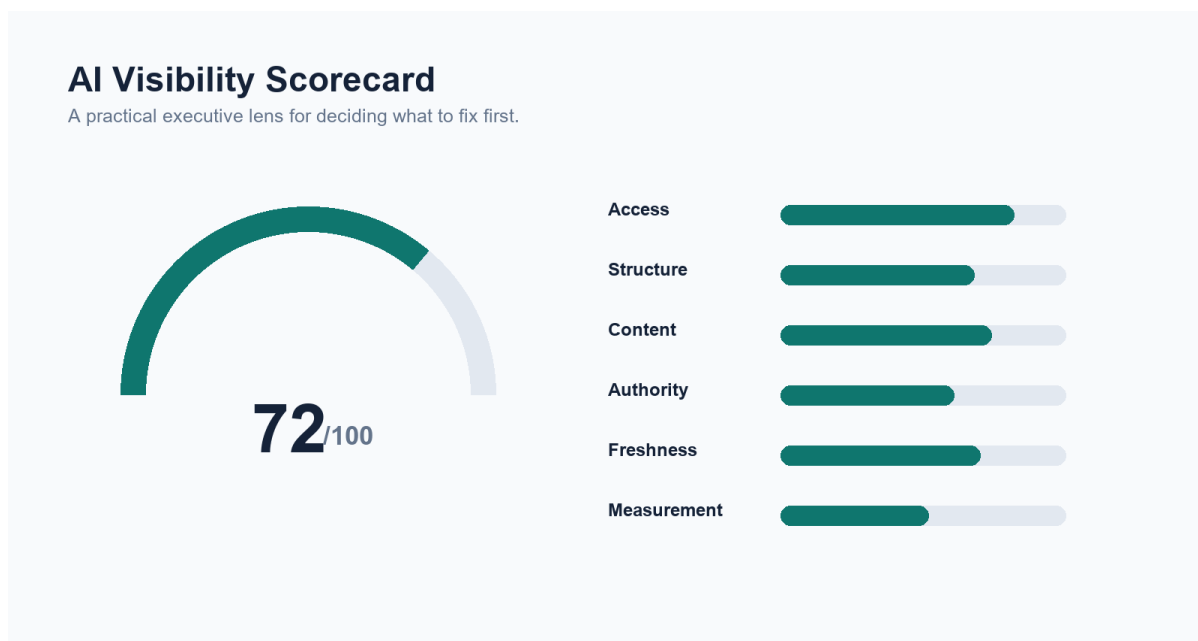


Figure 7: The scorecard turns AI visibility into an executive prioritization conversation.

A useful scorecard should look across the full evidence layer. Crawlability matters because AI and search systems cannot use content they cannot access. Structured data matters because it clarifies entities, products, services, locations, authors, FAQs, and relationships. Content depth matters because AI needs enough context to answer real buyer questions. Differentiation matters because AI summaries tend to compress weak positioning. Authority matters because recommendations require confidence. Measurement matters because the system changes over time.

Dimension	Executive question	Why it matters
Access	Can search and AI crawlers reach the important content?	Blocked or hidden content creates accidental invisibility.
Structure	Is the business described in machine-readable ways?	Schema, clean architecture, and consistent entities reduce ambiguity.
Content depth	Does the site answer the real questions customers ask?	Thin content is hard to cite, summarize, and trust.
Differentiation	Can AI explain why this company is different?	Generic language creates flattening risk.
Authority	Is there proof beyond marketing claims?	Evidence, links, citations, reviews, and case examples build confidence.
Freshness	Is the evidence current?	Old or inconsistent information can make AI answers vague or wrong.
Measurement	Can the company observe movement?	Visibility work needs a cadence, not a one-time audit.

The most useful outcome is prioritization. A company may have dozens of issues, but not all issues deserve equal attention. Some fixes protect crawlability. Some improve interpretation. Some clarify differentiation. Some support conversion after the click. The executive job is to decide which improvements have the greatest business value first.

Chapter 7: From Audit to Action

An audit is only valuable if it changes decisions. Many companies already have reports, dashboards, SEO exports, site-speed tests, content inventories, and analytics views. The problem is rarely lack of information. The problem is knowing which findings matter, which are noise, which require executive support, and which will actually move the business forward.

From Audit to Action

The value is not the report. It is the prioritized path from finding to business result.



Figure 8: The audit matters when it becomes a prioritized path to business impact.

That is why an AI visibility audit should produce a ranked backlog, not just a list of defects. The backlog should separate foundational access issues from content clarity issues, evidence gaps, structured-data opportunities, paid-test learning, social amplification, and conversion follow-up. A blocked crawler is different from a weak comparison page. A missing schema object is different from a vague value proposition. A broken landing page is different from a lack of proof. They may all affect visibility, but they require different owners.

The practical path is to sequence work in three waves. First, fix anything that prevents discovery or interpretation: crawl rules, firewall settings, indexability, redirects, broken links, missing structured data, and incomplete source-of-truth pages. Second, build the evidence layer: buyer-question pages, FAQs, comparison content, case studies, product data, testimonials, video transcripts, and proof pages. Third, operate the system: retest prompts, monitor citations and grounding signals where available, feed paid and social learning back into content, and review competitor movement.

This is where experience matters. Some recommendations are technically correct but commercially minor. Others are small, fast, and high-leverage. The work is not just finding what is wrong. It is deciding what to fix first, who should own it, and how the business will know whether the fix mattered.

Chapter 8: Building an AI Visibility Operating Model

AI visibility cannot live in one department. Marketing controls messaging and content. IT and security control access. SEO controls discoverability and technical hygiene. Product and ecommerce teams control product truth. Sales and customer service hear the real questions buyers ask. Leadership controls prioritization and funding. If those groups operate separately, AI learns the business from fragments.

A related development belongs in this operating model: Harvard Business Review's research on agentic AI describes a marketplace where AI agents increasingly act on both the buyer's and the seller's side of a transaction, not just answer questions. As that shift matures, the same evidence layer that makes a business legible to a chatbot, structured data, current product facts, clear policies, will also determine whether a shopping or booking agent can transact with the business directly. [9]

AI Visibility as an Operating Discipline

The evidence layer improves when the organization refreshes it continuously.

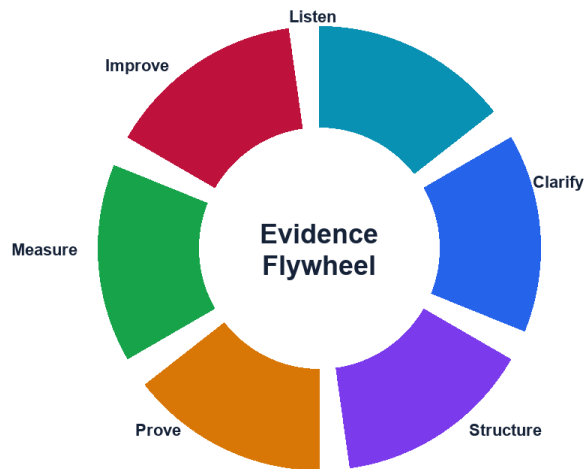


Figure 9: AI visibility becomes stronger when the evidence layer is refreshed continuously.

The operating model should be simple enough to survive normal business pressure. A monthly AI visibility review is a practical starting point. The agenda should cover access issues, prompt tests, competitor comparisons, source-of-truth updates, high-value content gaps, paid-search learning, social content that gained traction, and the next backlog priorities. This does not need to become a large governance program. It needs ownership, cadence, and a bias toward business impact.

Measurement tools are beginning to move in this direction. For example, Bing's AI Performance reporting surfaces pages cited in AI answers, grounding queries, citation share, and topic patterns. That should be treated as one early signal of where the market is going, not as the only measurement surface that matters. Companies will increasingly manage not only rankings and traffic, but also whether their content is used as evidence in AI-mediated answers across assistants, answer engines, video platforms, and traditional search. [14]

The long-term winner will not be the company that runs one audit and declares victory. It will be the company that treats AI visibility as part of digital operations: listening to customer questions, clarifying the story, structuring the evidence, proving authority, measuring movement, and improving continuously.

Conclusion: What Companies Need to Do Now

The practical lesson is not that every company needs to chase every AI trend. The practical lesson is that customers are changing how they gather information, compare choices, and decide who to trust. If a business wants to be considered in that environment, it has to make itself easier for both people and machines to understand.

That starts with the basics: allow legitimate crawlers to reach important public content, build clear source-of-truth pages, use structured data where it helps interpretation, and make the company's expertise specific rather than generic. Then the business has to organize proof: customer stories, YouTube testimonials, reviews, case studies, product data, service explanations, leadership perspective, and third-party validation.

The next step is operating discipline. AI visibility is not a one-time audit that sits in a folder. It should become part of the digital rhythm of the company: review the evidence layer, test the questions customers ask, watch competitor movement, refresh pages that matter, connect paid and social learning back to the website, and prioritize the work by business impact.

The companies that win in the AI Recommendation Economy will be the ones AI can understand, verify, distinguish, and confidently recommend. That is not just a marketing problem. It is a reputation problem, a revenue problem, and a leadership problem.

Appendix: Where Gateway Commerce Can Help

Gateway Commerce belongs near the end of this guide because the core ideas should stand on their own. The point is not that every company needs a consultant. The point is that many companies need a practical way to connect technical visibility findings to business priorities, revenue opportunities, customer behavior, and operating discipline.

Where Gateway Commerce Helps

Turning technical findings into a business-prioritized roadmap.



Figure 10: Gateway Commerce helps connect technical findings to business priorities.

Gateway Commerce helps companies answer a focused question: can AI, search engines, and customers understand the business well enough to recommend it, find it, trust it, and choose it? That work combines AI visibility auditing, digital strategy, ecommerce experience, SEO and paid-media interpretation, content structure, analytics review, and executive prioritization. The deliverable is not simply a report. It is a practical roadmap for what to fix first and why it matters.

A typical engagement can include an AI visibility assessment, competitor comparison, bot and firewall review, structured-data recommendations, source-of-truth page strategy, paid and organic query analysis, social evidence review, analytics baseline, and prioritized implementation backlog. For companies that already have marketing, IT, and content teams, Gateway Commerce can act as the translator between those groups so the work becomes coordinated rather than fragmented.

Short Bio

Arthur G. Huggard

Arthur G. Huggard is the founder of Gateway Commerce and a digital commerce executive with more than two decades of experience connecting technology investments to measurable revenue growth. His background spans B2B scientific products, specialty retail, outdoor products, department-store ecommerce, and consumer brands. Across those roles, his work has focused on the same practical question at the center of this guide: can the right customer find the business, understand the offer, trust the evidence, and complete the transaction?

At Sigma-Aldrich, Art led ecommerce transformation that produced more than \$230 million in additional revenue through the ecommerce channel, with revenue increasing more than 14% annually for three years and website visits growing 25% year over year. At Hudson's Bay Company, he directed ecommerce and omnichannel programs across more than \$500 million in digital revenue and helped deliver more than \$150

million in annual growth through initiatives such as ship-from-store and pickup-in-store. At Bass Pro Shops, he drove 14%+ year-over-year digital revenue growth and improved page-one keyword visibility by 30%. At Build-A-Bear, he helped drive \$50 million in ecommerce revenue growth, 20-140% year-over-year digital revenue growth, and significant gains from new digital experiences and marketplace expansion.

That background shapes the Gateway Commerce point of view. AI visibility is not a novelty project, a prompt exercise, or another generic SEO checklist. It is part of the revenue system. The goal is to help companies become easier for AI to understand, easier for customers to find, and easier for executives to prioritize.

An audit tells you what is wrong. Experience tells you what to fix first - and why it matters.

Contact Gateway Commerce

If you would like help applying this guide to your own business, or want a second opinion on your AI visibility posture, Gateway Commerce is available for a focused conversation.

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Location	St. Louis, Missouri (working with clients nationally)

Research Notes

The guide draws on a mix of official search documentation, AI and search-industry sources, business research, and academic work on digital trust, electronic word-of-mouth, online reviews, social proof, video discovery, and customer decision-making. These notes are intended to support review and refinement before final publication. A few additional sources are included as supporting background reading and are not individually cited inline.

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[2] Google Ads Help. About measuring paid and organic search results. [source link](#)

[3] Google Search Central. Qualify your outbound links to Google. [source link](#)

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[5] Google Search Central. Introduction to structured data markup in Google Search. [source link](#)

- [6] Bing Webmaster Guidelines. Create content that is clear, focused, and useful. [source link](#)
- [7] Bing Webmaster Tools. Marking up your site: Overview. [source link](#)
- [8] Bing Webmaster Tools. Link building. [source link](#)
- [9] Harvard Business Review. Preparing Your Brand for Agentic AI. [source link](#)
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- [16] McKinsey. The state of AI in 2025. [source link](#)
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